

Primary Source Analysis Chart: Contact Narratives

Analytical framework for comparing rhetoric, tone, and author purpose across early colonial texts.

Text & Author	Rhetorical Strategies & Appeals	Tone & Key Diction	Author Purpose & Target Audience	Narrative Friction / Underlying Bias
Letters of Discovery Christopher Columbus (1493)	- Hyperbolic descriptions - Cataloging natural wealth - Framing docility	Exuberant, triumphalist, commercial	Persuade Spanish Monarchs to fund future imperial voyages	Erases Indigenous governance to present land as unclaimed and ready for seizure.
The General History of Virginia Capt. John Smith (1624)	- Heroic third-person framing - Dramatic captivity narrative - Ethos of military prowess	Self-aggrandizing, dominant, adversarial	Cement personal legacy and encourage English colonization of Jamestown	Frames Indigenous leaders as hostiles needing conquest, downplaying English reliance on Powhatan trade.
Discourse of Peace & War Chief Powhatan (1609)	- Rhetorical questions - Contrast of peace vs. war - Appeal to reason (Logos)	Diplomatic, firm, paternal, urgent	Deter English aggression and establish mutually beneficial trade	Exposes the contradiction of English military force when peaceful co-existence offers greater survival.